

Channels Pilot — Participant Guide

Welcome to the Channels pilot! You are part of the second cohort testing Channels, a new real-time messaging feature built directly into Dartmouth Chat.

This guide covers what you need to know and what we are asking you to pay attention to during the two-week pilot.

What is Channels?

Channels adds Slack-like group messaging to Dartmouth Chat. Instead of only having 1-on-1 AI conversations, you can now have real-time discussions with other people — and bring AI models into those conversations.

Channel Types

Type	Icon	Who can create	Who can see it
Standard channel	#	Admins only	All users with Channels permission
Group channel		Anyone	Only invited members
Direct message	Profile photo	Anyone	Just the selected participants

Getting Started

Find Channels

Open the **left sidebar** in Dartmouth Chat. You will see a **Channels** section. Click it to expand the list. You should already see **#dcal-pilot**, which was created for this pilot.

Post a Message

Click into any channel and type in the message box at the bottom. Press **Enter** to send.

Reply in a Thread

Click the **reply icon** on any message to open a threaded reply. This keeps side conversations organized without cluttering the main channel.

React to a Message

Hover over a message and click the **emoji icon** to add a reaction.

Pin a Message

Hover over a message, click the  menu, and select **Pin**. Pinned messages are accessible from the  icon in the channel header.

Upload a File

Drag a file into the message input, or click the **attachment icon**.

Enable Browser Notifications

So you do not miss messages from the other pilot member, turn on browser notifications:

1. Click your **profile icon** (bottom-left) → **Settings**
2. Go to **General**
3. Toggle **Notifications** to **On** — your browser will ask for permission; click Allow
4. Optionally, go to **Interface** and toggle **Always Play Notification Sound** if you want an audio alert even when the tab is in the background

Note: There are no per-channel notification controls yet. This toggle applies to all of Dartmouth Chat.

Mentioning People, AI Models, and Channels

This is one of the most powerful features to try during the pilot.

@mention a person

Type @ and select a user from the list. They will see the message highlighted.

@mention an AI model

Type @ and select a model (e.g., **Claude Sonnet 4.6**, **GPT-OSS 120b**). Ask it a question right in the channel — the AI will respond inline, visible to everyone.

Example:

@GPT-OSS 120b, We're redesigning the assessment strategy for an introductory biology course. Suggest 3 formative assessment techniques that work well in large lectures and explain why each supports student learning.

How the AI sees your conversation: When you @mention a model, it only sees the **thread** it is part of — not the rest of the channel. If you @mention a model in a top-level message, it sees that message alone. If you @mention it inside a thread, it sees the thread history (up to 50 messages). It does **not** see other threads or other messages in the channel.

You can also reply to a previous AI response to continue the conversation — the model will pick up the thread context automatically.

Tip: For best results, include relevant context directly in your message. Do not assume the model has read the rest of the channel.

Want the AI to search the web or use other tools? See [Using AI Models with Tools in Channels](#) below.

#mention a channel

Type **#** and select a channel to create a cross-reference link.

Using AI Models with Tools in Channels

When you @mention a base model (e.g., Claude Sonnet 4.6, GPT-5.5), it responds using only its built-in "knowledge". If you want the model to **search the web**, **generate images**, or use any other tool, you need to @mention a **Workspace Model** that has those tools enabled.

This is the same approach used in [Automations](#) — equip a Workspace Model with tools, then @mention it in a channel.

How to Create a Workspace Model with Tools

1. Go to **Workspace** → **Models** (left sidebar → Workspace)
2. Click **+ Create a Model**
3. Fill in:
 - **Name** — something descriptive, e.g., "Claude Sonnet + Web Search"
 - **Base Model** — select the underlying model (e.g., Claude Sonnet 4.6)
4. Scroll down to **Tools** and check the features you need:
 - ☒ **Web Search** — lets the model search the internet
 - ☒ **Image Generation** — lets the model generate images
 - ...
5. Click **Save**
6. Now go to any channel, type @, and select your new Workspace Model

Why is this needed? Base models do not have tools attached by default. Workspace Models let you "pre-configure" a model with specific tools and capabilities that will be available whenever you @mention it — in channels, automations, or regular chats.

Example: Researching Pedagogy in a Channel Thread

1. Create a Workspace Model called "Claude + Web Search"
 - Base Model: Claude Sonnet 4.6
 - Tools: ☒ Web Search
2. In a channel thread, @mention it:

@Claude + Web Search, What does recent research say about the effectiveness of specifications grading in undergraduate STEM courses? Include links to key studies or summaries.

3. The model will search the web and respond inline — visible to everyone in the thread
-

Creating Your Own Channels

You can create **group channels** and **direct messages** yourself:

1. Click the **+** button next to "Channels" in the sidebar
2. Choose the type:

- **Group Channel** — invite-only, you pick the members
 - **Direct Message** — 1-on-1 conversation with another user
3. Give it a name (for group channels) and invite members
 4. Start chatting!

Note: Only admins can create standard (public) channels. If you need one, just ask.

What We Are Asking You to Do

Over the next two weeks, please:

1. **Use Channels for real conversations** — sharing ideas, discussing course designs, brainstorming with AI
2. **Try the AI @mention feature** at least a few times — see how it works in a group context
3. **Try @mentioning a Workspace Model with tools** — create a Workspace Model with Web Search enabled and @mention it in a channel to see how tool-equipped models work in group conversations
4. **Create at least one group channel or DM** to test the creation flow
5. **Note anything confusing, broken, or missing** — post it in the pinned "Feedback & Friction" thread in #dcal-pilot, or reach out to us directly anytime

What to Keep Track Of (for the Final Survey)

At the end of the pilot, we will ask you to fill out a short survey. Here are the things worth paying attention to as you use Channels so you are ready:

Usage patterns

- How often are you using Channels? Daily, a few times a week, less?
- Which channel type do you use most — standard, group, or DM?
- What are you using it for — discussion, AI queries, file sharing, quick messages?

AI @mentions

- When you @mention an AI model, are the responses useful?
- Does the thread-scoped context work well enough, or do you find yourself repeating information the model should already know?
- Do you prefer asking the AI in a channel thread (where others can see) or in a separate 1-on-1 chat?

Workspace Models and tools

- Was it clear that you could use a Workspace Model with tools in a channel?
- Was creating a Workspace Model straightforward?
- Did tools (e.g., Web Search) meaningfully improve the AI responses in channel conversations?

UX and clarity

- Is the difference between standard channels, group channels, and DMs obvious?
- Can you find what you need without help — creating channels, managing members, pinning messages?
- Is anything confusing or hard to discover?

Comparison to existing tools

- How does Channels compare to Slack or Teams for your workflow?
- Does it replace any existing communication, complement it, or feel redundant?

Missing features

- What would make Channels more useful? Think about:
 - Notifications (push, email digest)
 - Search across channel messages
 - Channel archiving
 - Message edit history
 - Threading improvements
 - Anything else

Known Limitations

A few things to be aware of during the pilot:

What	Details
AI context	AI models only see the thread they are mentioned in — not the rest of the channel. Include context in your @mention for best results.
No archiving	Channels can be deleted but not archived. Please do not delete any channels during the pilot.
No edit history	You can edit messages, but previous versions are not saved.
Credits	AI responses in channels use credits just like regular chats.
Tools	AI models only have access to tools if you @mention a Workspace Model that has those tools enabled. Base models do not have tools by default.

Quick Reference

Action	How
Find channels	Left sidebar → Channels section
Post a message	Type in the input box, press Enter
Reply in a thread	Click the reply icon on a message
React	Hover → emoji icon

Action	How
Pin a message	Hover → menu → Pin
View pinned messages	Channel header → 📌 icon
@mention a person	Type @ → select user
@mention an AI model	Type @ → select model
@mention a model with tools	Create a Workspace Model with tools enabled, then @ → select it
#mention a channel	Type # → select channel
Create a group channel	Sidebar → Channels + button → Group Channel
Create a DM	Sidebar → Channels + button → Direct Message
Manage members	Channel header → people icon
Upload a file	Drag and drop, or click attachment icon

Need Help?

Reach out anytime during the pilot. You can also post questions directly in **#dcal-pilot**.